

The Brand Naming Process Explained

How to develop a brand name that is distinctive, ownable, and built to grow — and how to evaluate candidates without defaulting to personal preference.

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Brand naming is the creative process with the highest stakes and the least margin for error. Unlike a visual identity that can evolve through a refresh, a name change requires significant investment and carries real brand equity risk. Getting naming right the first time matters.

What makes a name work

Before evaluating any specific name, establish the criteria for what makes a good name in your specific context.

- ☐ Distinctive: easy to distinguish from competitor names and not easily confused with adjacent brands
- ☐ Memorable: can be recalled after one encounter, not just recognised when seen
- ☐ Pronounceable: can be said and heard correctly across the languages of your target markets
- ☐ Scalable: doesn't lock the brand into a category, geography, or product line it may outgrow
- ☐ Available: cleared for trademark in your primary markets, available as a .com domain
- ☐ Legible: works in your logo — some names look poor in the typefaces appropriate to the brand's visual direction

The types of names

Understanding the spectrum of naming types helps calibrate expectations about how hard a name will need to work.

- ☐ Descriptive names: communicate the product immediately but are hard to trademark and can limit future positioning
- ☐ Evocative names: suggest something about the brand without stating it — more flexible but require more investment to build associations
- ☐ Invented names: highest distinctiveness and trademark availability, require the most time to build meaning
- ☐ Founder/person names: strong for service businesses, often limiting for product companies
- ☐ Acronyms: almost always a mistake — they're arbitrary and forgettable by design

The naming process

A rigorous naming process produces better candidates than creative brainstorming alone.

- ☐ Brief: define the positioning, the naming criteria, and the territories you want to explore (and avoid)
- ☐ Exploration: generate a large number of candidates across multiple naming types and territories — 200+ before filtering
- ☐ Initial screening: filter for basic availability (quick trademark and domain check) and criteria alignment
- ☐ Long list review: apply qualitative criteria to the remaining names
- ☐ Finalist testing: test 5–10 finalists with a representative sample of your target audience (not colleagues or stakeholders)
- ☐ Legal clearance: full trademark search in all relevant territories before selection

- ☐ Selection: choose the name that best fits the criteria — not the one that generates the most enthusiasm in an internal meeting
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| Common naming mistakes

The mistakes we see most often are preventable with the right process.

- ☐ Choosing based on internal preference rather than external criteria: the CEO's favourite name is rarely the right one
 - ☐ Shortcutting the availability check: assuming .io domain availability means the name is clear — it doesn't
 - ☐ Testing with existing customers instead of target audience: your current users have different associations than the prospects you're trying to win
 - ☐ Names that are too safe: distinctiveness requires taking a position, and positions can feel uncomfortable before they feel right
 - ☐ Invented spellings of common words: confusing and patronising
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| How long does naming take?

A proper naming process takes 4–6 weeks from brief to final selection. The phases of exploration, screening, and legal clearance cannot be meaningfully compressed. Rushed naming processes produce names that create problems later.
